

Why do half of new Swiss companies close within five years?

Data, not hype: what really decides whether a new Swiss company survives, and what founders, investors and cantons can do about it.

50.7%

of companies founded in 2018 still existed five years later

25 points

between the best and worst sector: health 63%, hospitality 38%

49% vs 68%

survival of one-person starts vs companies with 10+ employees



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BEFORE YOU START

About this report

Switzerland creates record numbers of companies every year. Half of them are gone within five years. This report asks why, using the method a strategy consultant would use: one sharp question, testable hypotheses, official data, and a clear "so what".



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I built this project end to end: I framed the question, collected the raw data from the Federal Statistical Office (BFS) and the Swiss Venture Capital Report, cleaned it in Python, built the analysis and all four data charts in **Power BI**, and researched every "why" against at least two sources. It is the first study in a series of independent consulting projects.

How to read it

The report is long on purpose, but it is built so you never have to read it front to back. Every section opens with an **At a glance** box and a reading time. Cross-references such as **Section 5** (p. 14) take you straight to the related point.

KEY FACT · the numbers that carry a finding

REMEMBER · the one point to take away

NOTE · limits, caveats and data quality

SCENARIO · what could happen next, and how likely

Facts vs judgement. Every number carries a source. Anything called a *possible explanation*, a rating or a likelihood is my own reasoning and is marked as such. Side notes in the margin add context without breaking the flow.

Four ways to read it

If you have...	Read
2 minutes	Executive summary (p. 4)
15 minutes	Part 1, the five findings with charts (Part 1 (p. 5))
An interest in AI	Part 2, who gains, who loses, and why AI success rates mislead (Part 2 (p. 17))
A specific sector or canton	Part 3, eight sector deep dives and the regional reading (Part 3 (p. 23))

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY · 2 MIN READ

 The answer in two minutes

New Swiss companies mostly fail because of how they start and which market they enter, not because of where they are or how much money they raise.

50.7%

survive five years (2018 founding cohort, Switzerland)

46.8%

survival in Zug, the canton that founds the most companies per resident

63%

survival in health, the only sector protected by licences

38%

survival in hospitality, the lowest of any sector

49 → 68%

survival from one-person starts to firms with 10+ employees

32%

of Swiss venture capital now goes to AI startups (5% two years earlier)

The answer in five points

- 1. How a company starts matters most.** Solo starts survive 49%, teams of 10 or more 68%. A GmbH or AG, which needs share capital, survives better than a sole proprietorship. [Section 5](#) (p. 14)
- 2. Which market it enters comes next.** Easy-entry, crowded sectors (hospitality, retail, IT services, consulting) survive worst; health, protected by qualifications, survives best. [Section 3](#) (p. 10)
- 3. Location matters less,** and mostly through the type of company a place attracts. Zug founds 2.5 times more companies per resident than Zurich, and keeps the fewest. [Section 2](#) (p. 8)
- 4. Money does not explain survival.** Venture capital reaches about 350 of more than 46,000 new companies a year. Lucerne gets almost none and survives as well as Zurich. [Section 4](#) (p. 12)
- 5. AI is not yet the main cause of failure,** but it crowds knowledge work, pulls capital to a few AI firms, and makes the AI decision itself a risk for small companies. [Section 7](#) (p. 18)

REMEMBER

The survivors start with a team, enter a market with a real barrier or stable demand, and keep their early bets small and reversible.

NOTE · WHAT CANNOT BE PROVEN YET

AI's direct effect on five-year survival. The data that would show it, the 2023 founding cohort at year five, will only be published around 2030. Everything about AI in this report is strong circumstantial evidence, not proof.

01

PART 1

The data: what happens and where

*Five cantons, thirteen sectors, one founding year followed for five years.
What the official numbers actually show.*

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PART 1 · METHOD · 4 MIN READ

01 The question and how I answered it

One sharp question, five testable parts, and only official data to test them.

AT A GLANCE

METHOD

- Main question: why do half of new Swiss companies close within five years, and what makes the other half survive?
- Split into five parts: regions, sectors, money, size, AI.
- Data: BFS company demography, BFS population, Swiss Venture Capital Report 2026.

Only **50.7%** of the companies founded in Switzerland in 2018 still existed five years later. For every two new companies, one was gone by 2023. A founding boom means little if half of it disappears.

The issue tree

Consultants break a big question into parts that do not overlap and together cover the whole (a "MECE" issue tree). Each part got a hypothesis before I looked at the data:

#	Sub-question	Starting hypothesis	Result
1	Regions: which cantons do well, and why?	High-founding cantons survive less	Supported §2 (p. 8)
2	Sectors: which industries survive?	Hype sectors survive worse than average	Supported §3 (p. 10)
3	Money: does funding decide survival?	Low-funding regions survive less	Rejected §4 (p. 12)
4	Size: does how you start matter?	Teams survive longer than solo founders	Supported §5 (p. 14)
5	AI: who gains, who loses?	AI creates winners and losers	Partly, not yet provable §7 (p. 18)

REMEMBER

A rejected hypothesis is a result, not a failure. Hypothesis 3 was wrong, and that turned out to be one of the most useful findings.

The data, and why each source

Data	Source	Why this source
Survival of new companies by canton, sector, size, legal form	BFS company demography	Counts only genuinely new companies, excludes mergers, relaunches and holdings, and follows each founding year for five years
New companies, closures, active companies per canton and industry, 2013–2023	BFS STAT-TAB	Gives counts, not only rates

Data	Source	Why this source
Population per canton, end of 2023	BFS STATPOP, cantonal statistics offices	Turns counts into comparable rates per 1,000 residents
Venture capital by sector, canton and round, 2025	Swiss Venture Capital Report 2026	The only complete record of Swiss startup funding

Three design choices

- **Why the 2018 cohort:** it is the most recent founding year with a full five years of follow-up (2018 to 2023). BFS data runs about two years behind.
- **Why five cantons:** each plays a different role. Zurich is the hub, Basel-Stadt the life-science cluster, Zug the formation machine, Lucerne the rising challenger, Bern the control case.
- **Why rates per 1,000 residents:** Zurich has twelve times Zug's population, so raw counts would only measure size.

SIDE NOTE

The raw BFS files came in German and Italian, with merged headers and footnotes. I translated them, put one value per row, mapped standard canton codes and left unavailable values blank instead of zero, so they could not distort averages.

KEY FACT · QUALITY CHECKS

The cleaned canton data adds up to 46,883 new companies in 2023, against 46,931 published by BFS; the gap is cells BFS hides for confidentiality. The venture capital tables by canton and by sector both add up to exactly CHF 2,948m.

PART 1 · FINDING 1 · 4 MIN READ

02

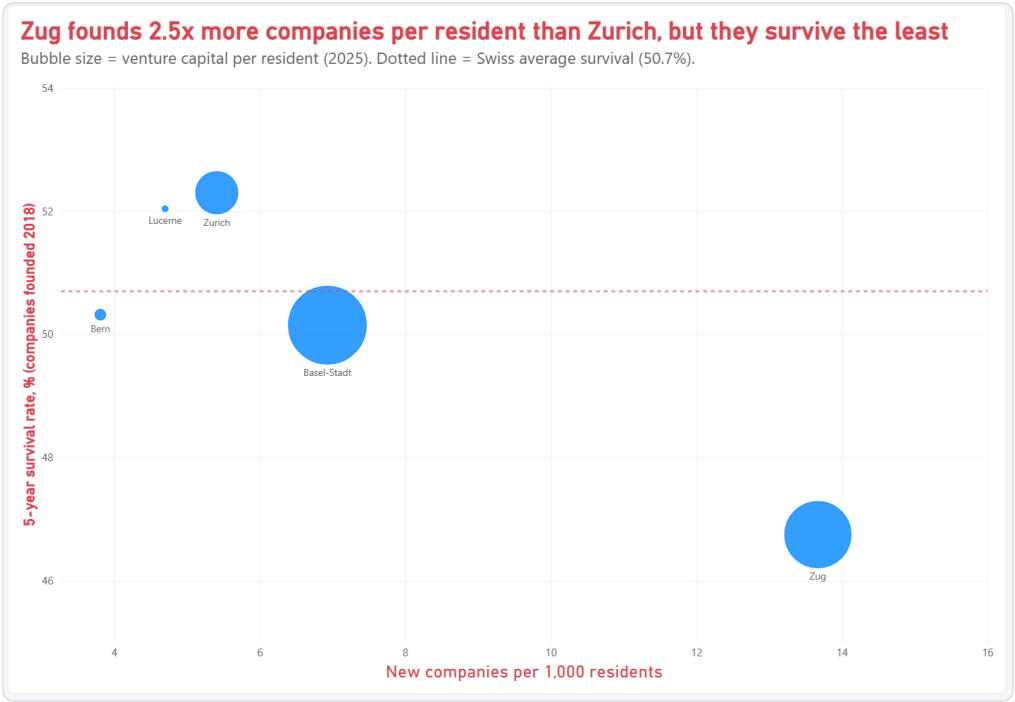
Regions: Zug founds the most and keeps the fewest

More foundings do not mean a healthier ecosystem.

AT A GLANCE

FINDING 1

- Zug creates 13.7 new companies per 1,000 residents, about 2.5 times Zurich.
- Yet only 46.8% survive five years, the lowest of the five cantons, in 2013 and 2018 alike.
- Zug is a revolving door: highest founding rate and highest closure rate.



New companies per 1,000 residents (2023) against 5-year survival (2018 cohort). Bubble size: venture capital per resident (2025).

Built by Salman Shaik in Power BI · Data: BFS, SVCR

Canton	Survival, 2013 cohort	Survival, 2018 cohort	Solo starts, 2018	New per 100 active, 2021	Closures per 100 active, 2021
Zurich	51.3%	52.3%	82%	7.3	6.4
Lucerne	48.7%	52.0%	81%	6.9	5.8
Bern	49.2%	50.3%	86%	6.3	6.0
Basel-Stadt	46.5%	50.1%	83%	7.7	6.1
Zug	46.7%	46.8%	77%	10.3	7.5
Switzerland	49.2%	50.7%	83%		

Source: BFS company demography; own calculations.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

- Zug's weakness is structural. It was also last for the 2013 cohort, so this is not one bad year.

- **Size does not explain it.** Zug has the fewest solo starts (77%), and solo starts survive worst nationally. On size alone, Zug should do better. [Section 5](#) (p. 14)
- **Lucerne is the quiet improver:** survival up from 48.7% to 52.0%, the biggest gain, and the lowest closure rate.

POSSIBLE EXPLANATIONS FOR ZUG (MY HYPOTHESES)

- **Foreign-owned companies:** nationally they survive only 35% ([Section 5](#) (p. 14)), and Zug attracts many of them.
- **Mobile, tax-driven firms** that can leave as easily as they arrive.
- **Crypto exposure:** the 2018 cohort lived through crypto crashes in 2018 and 2022. But crypto explains only part of it. [Section 12.5](#) (p. 32)

NOTE · SHELL COMPANIES RULED OUT

BFS company demography excludes holding companies and counts only firms with real market activity. Zug's low survival therefore comes from real operating companies, not mailbox shells.

REMEMBER

Zug maximises volume, not durability. A canton that measures success by registrations will celebrate exactly the wrong number.

PART 1 · FINDING 2 · 4 MIN READ

03 Sectors: the hype sectors survive below average

What a company does matters five times more than where it is.

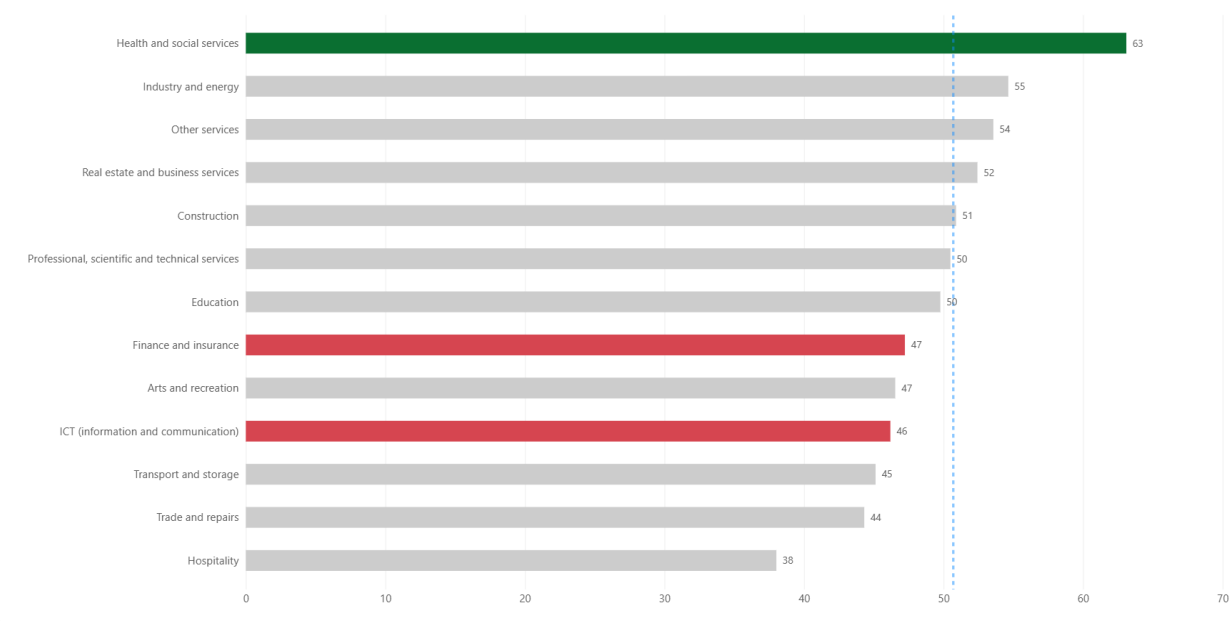
AT A GLANCE

FINDING 2

- Only 46% of new ICT and 47% of new finance companies reach year five, against 50.7% overall.
- Health survives best (63%), hospitality worst (38%).
- The sector gap (25 points) is about five times the canton gap (about 5 points).

Hype sectors survive below average: only 46% of new ICT and 47% of new finance companies reach year 5

5-year survival of companies founded in 2018, by sector. Dotted line = Swiss average (50.7%). Source: BFS.



5-year survival of companies founded in 2018, by sector. Dotted line: Swiss average (50.7%).

Built by Salman Shaik in Power BI · Data: BFS

KEY FACT

25 points

between the best sector (health, 63%) and the worst (hospitality, 38%). Choosing health over hospitality changes the odds far more than choosing Zurich over Zug.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

- **ICT and finance are below average, but not the worst.** Trade, transport and hospitality do worse.
- **Construction, real estate and business services sit near the average:** ordinary local businesses with steady demand.

POSSIBLE EXPLANATIONS

- **Low entry barriers:** anyone with a laptop can open an IT or financial consulting firm.
- **Regulation as protection:** health needs licences, which keep weak entrants out.
- **Stable demand:** healthcare is needed in every cycle; software and fintech depend on funding cycles.
- **Thin margins in hospitality,** plus COVID closures inside the five-year window.

→ **Check this point** in the five-forces analysis: health is the only sector with restricted entry. **Section 11** (p. 26)

REMEMBER

Hype does not bring durability. The honest message is not "tech is the worst place to start" but "the sectors that get the most attention do not produce the most durable companies".

PART 1 · FINDING 3 · 4 MIN READ

04 Money: venture capital does not explain survival

The hypothesis I got wrong, and why that matters.

AT A GLANCE

FINDING 3

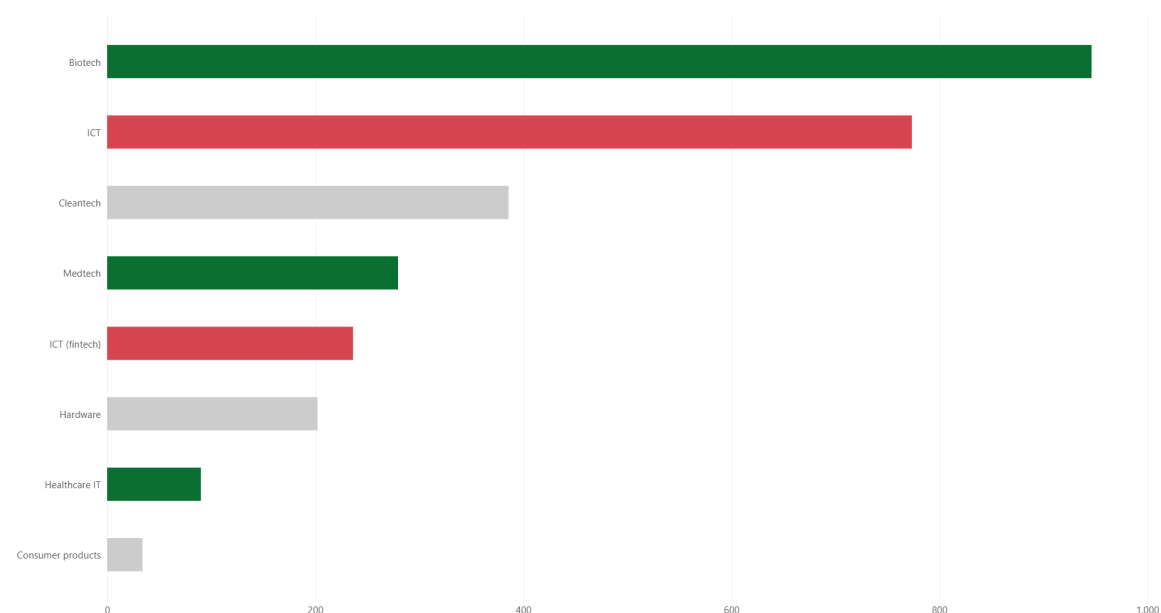
- Zug receives more VC per resident than Zurich and still survives worst.
- Lucerne receives almost none and survives as well as Zurich.
- VC reaches about 350 rounds a year against more than 46,000 new companies.

Canton	VC 2025 (CHF m)	Rounds 2025	VC per resident (CHF)	5-year survival
Basel-Stadt	572.3	18	2,861	50.1%
Zug	268.6	30	2,026	46.8%
Zurich	1,192.5	151	745	52.3%
Bern	≥ 17.8	14	≥ 17	50.3%
Lucerne	0.1	1	0.3	52.0%

Source: [Swiss Venture Capital Report 2026](#); survival BFS. Bern and Lucerne are not shown separately in the report: I rebuilt them from the list of individual rounds, so they are minimums.

A third of Swiss venture capital goes to ICT and fintech, the sectors where new companies survive below average

VC invested in 2025, CHF m. Green = health-related, red = ICT and fintech. Sector definitions differ from BFS, so read this as directional. Source: SVCR 2026.



Venture capital invested in 2025 by sector, CHF m. Green: health-related; red: ICT and fintech.

Built by Salman Shaik in Power BI · Data: SVCR 2026

WHY MONEY DOES NOT EXPLAIN SURVIVAL

- **VC reaches very few companies.** Most new companies are bakeries, consultancies and tradespeople that never seek venture capital.
- **VC is a bet on fast growth, not on survival.** Investors accept that most of their startups fail, as long as a few become very large.
- **Lucerne shows another model:** self-funding, bank loans and steady local customers (a hypothesis to research).
- At sector level, investors partly back the best survivors: health-related startups got about 45% of 2025 VC; ICT and fintech about 34%.

SIDE NOTE

BFS "health" includes clinics and care homes; VC "biotech" means drug development. The sector comparison between the two sources is directional only.

REMEMBER

Venture capital cannot explain the survival of companies it never touches.

PART 1 · FINDING 4 · 4 MIN READ

05 Size: how a company starts matters most

The clearest pattern in the whole dataset: do not start alone.

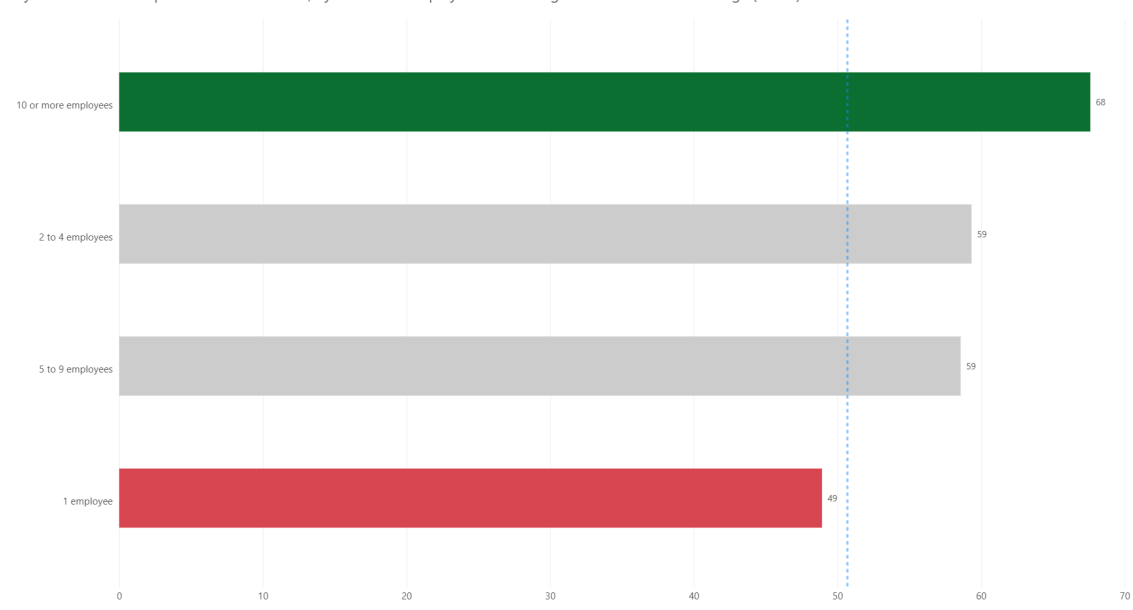
AT A GLANCE

FINDING 4

- 49% of one-person starts survive five years; 68% of companies starting with 10+ employees.
- GmbH (56%) and AG (55%) beat sole proprietorships (48%). Foreign companies: 35%.
- About 83% of new Swiss companies start with one employee: the weakest start is the most common.

Size matters: only 49% of one-person starts survive five years, versus 68% of companies starting with 10+ employees

5-year survival of companies founded in 2018, by number of employees at founding. Dotted line = Swiss average (50.7%). Source: BFS.



5-year survival of companies founded in 2018, by number of employees at founding. **Built by Salman Shaik in Power BI · Data: BFS**

Legal form at founding	5-year survival
GmbH (limited liability)	56.1%
AG (public limited)	54.8%
Cooperative	52.0%
Sole proprietorship	48.4%
Association or foundation	43.1%
Partnership	41.2%
Foreign company	35.1%

Source: BFS, 2018 cohort.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

- **The big jump is from one person to a small team:** +10 points from 1 to 2–4 employees; 2–4 to 5–9 adds nothing.
- **Capital at the start helps:** a GmbH needs CHF 20,000 and an AG CHF 100,000 of share capital.
- **Foreign companies survive worst**, which links back to Zug. [Section 2](#) (p. 8)

POSSIBLE EXPLANATIONS

- **Capacity:** one person must sell, deliver, do the accounts and absorb every setback.

- **Complementary skills:** a team combines, for example, product and sales.
- **Commitment:** hiring or putting in share capital signals a more serious, better-prepared project.

NOTE · CORRELATION, NOT CAUSE

Better-prepared founders may both hire more and survive more. Adding staff does not by itself make a company survive.

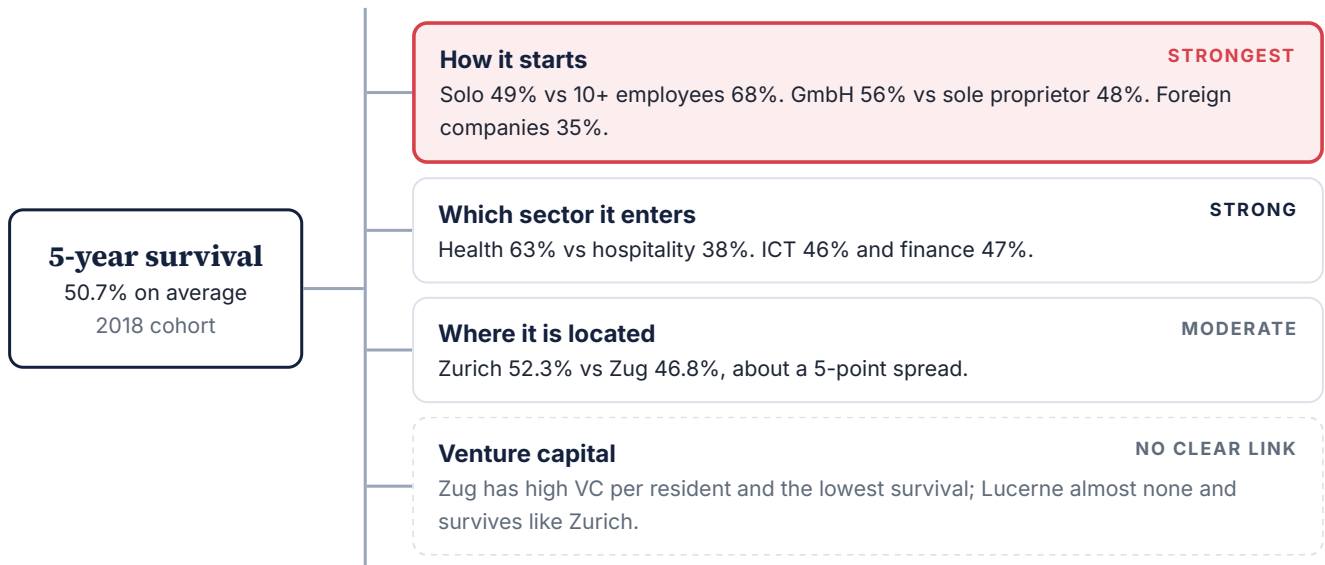
REMEMBER

The message is "do not start alone", not "the bigger the better".

PART 1 · SYNTHESIS · 2 MIN READ

06 How the factors connect

How a company starts matters more than where it is or what it raises.



Driver tree: own analysis of BFS and SVCR data. Ranking by the size of the survival gap each factor creates.

The factors also interact. Zug's low survival is not explained by size, since it has the fewest solo starts. It more likely comes from the *kind* of company Zug attracts: mobile, often foreign-owned firms in volatile fields such as crypto.

REMEMBER

Location matters mostly through the type of company it attracts. Money matters least of the four.

→ **Next:** does AI change this picture? [Section 7](#) (p. 18)

02

PART 2

The AI question

AI takes a third of Swiss venture capital. Is it saving companies, replacing them, or quietly burning their money?

IN THIS PART

- | | | |
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| 08 | The hidden denominator: why AI success rates mislead | p. 21 |

PART 2 · FINDING 5 · 7 MIN READ

07 AI: who gains, who loses

AI is not the main reason companies fail today. It is reshaping who enters, who gets funded, and who gets replaced.

AT A GLANCE

FINDING 5

- AI startups went from 5% to 32% of Swiss VC volume in two years.
- After ChatGPT, foundings fell in AI-replaceable services and rose in advisory and marketing, the sectors with the highest closure rates.
- Most AI projects show no measurable return; for small firms, the AI decision itself is a survival risk.

NOTE · WHAT CANNOT BE PROVEN YET

AI's direct effect on five-year survival. The data that would show it, the 2023 cohort at year five, will be published around 2030. This section is strong circumstantial evidence, not proof.

7.1 Where AI is boosting

Measure	Figure	Source
Share of Swiss VC volume going to AI startups	5% → 32% in two years; about CHF 1.1bn in 2025 (+206%)	EY Startup Barometer 2026
Swiss funding rounds involving AI startups	163 of 515 (32%)	EY Startup Barometer 2026
AI/ML among new Swiss deep-tech startups	One in four since 2022	Swiss Deep Tech Report 2026
Swiss SMEs consciously using AI	22% (2024) → 34% (2025)	AXA/Sotomo via kmu.admin.ch
AI share of global venture capital	About 50% in 2025; 80% in Q1 2026	Crunchbase via GCN

7.2 Where AI hurts: what Swiss founding data shows

I compared new company foundings in 2023, the first full year after ChatGPT, with 2022, using detailed BFS industry data.

Industry	AI exposure	New companies 2022→2023	Closures per 100 active, 2021
Advertising and market research	High	+15.8%	9.0
Management consulting	High	+3.7%	9.5
Information services	High	+3.5%	10.0
Design, translation, photography	High	-2.6%	8.4
Legal, tax and accounting	High	-6.0%	5.3
IT services	High	-7.1%	7.9
Publishing	High	-14.6%	6.1

Industry	AI exposure	New companies 2022→2023	Closures per 100 active, 2021
Office and business support	High	-15.6%	8.6
Health	Low	+16.7%	5.1
Specialised construction trades	Low	+5.8%	6.0
Personal services	Low	+1.5%	6.6
Restaurants and bars	Low	-9.3%	5.6

Source: BFS company demography; own calculations. The exposure grouping is my judgement, based on the ILO 2025 index, which finds clerical work most exposed, followed by digital professional work in media, software and finance.

KEY FACT

Foundings in high-exposure industries fell 1.3%; in low-exposure industries they rose 7.1%. The national total was flat (-0.1%).

DOING BUSINESSES SHRANK

Office support, publishing, IT services, legal and accounting: work whose output AI can now produce.

ADVISING AND SELLING BUSINESSES GREW

Advertising and consulting: AI makes it cheap for one person to open such a shop.

REMEMBER

AI pulls founders into the most fragile sectors: advertising and consulting already had 9 to 10 closures per 100 firms a year, against 5.1 in health.

7.3 Is AI actually useful in each sector?

Sector	What AI does there	Effect on companies
ICT	Core product	Helps; the only sector where AI is often the business model
Finance, pharma	Analysis, compliance, research	Helps, mostly large firms
Consulting, marketing	Cheap content and analysis	Lowers entry barriers, which brings crowding
Translation, publishing, office support	Does the core work itself	Hurts
Health	Admin support	Neutral; growth comes from demand
Construction, trade, hospitality	Little	Irrelevant; these fail for other reasons

REMEMBER

AI is valid where the work is text, code and data. The sectors with the most bankruptcies are physical and local, where AI barely matters.

7.4 Why AI fails where it fails

Barrier	Best available number	Source
No measurable return	95% of organisations saw no measurable P&L return within six months	MIT NANDA, 2025
Projects abandoned	42% dropped most AI initiatives (17% a year earlier); 46% of proofs of concept scrapped	S&P Global, 2025
Money in the wrong place	About half of budgets go to sales and marketing; returns show up in back-office automation	MIT NANDA
Shallow use	About 60% of Swiss firms use AI; only 2% of micro-firms use it systematically	UBS via Netzwoche
No data rules	Only 34% of SMEs have rules for data entered into AI tools; 23% under 10 employees	AXA/Sotomo 2025
Data protection	Local processing and data protection rated 8.7 / 10 in importance	EY Switzerland
Trust	46% willing to trust AI; 66% rely on output without checking; 56% made mistakes because of AI	KPMG & Univ. of Melbourne

REMEMBER

Investors are not against AI. The problem is the opposite: AI absorbs so much capital that non-AI startups get less.

7.5 The snowball: how one company winning hurts another

- 1. Capital is pulled to the top.** A few frontier labs absorb a large share of global funding; non-AI startups get less money at lower valuations. Swiss fintech fell from 41 rounds in 2024 to 30 in 2025 (SVCR).
- 2. Big models squeeze the specialists.** DeepL cut about 250 jobs, a quarter of its staff, and is still loss-making. If a translation AI champion is squeezed, human agencies are squeezed harder.
- 3. Cheap tools pull founders into crowded markets** that already have the highest closure rates.
- 4. Established firms burn money on badly chosen AI projects**, especially small firms with no data foundations.
- 5. Meanwhile, the largest failure wave is not about AI.** Construction, trade and hospitality lead the bankruptcies. [Section 12](#) (p. 27)

SIDE NOTE · SOLO FOUNDERS

In the US, about 36% of startups founded on Carta in 2025 had a solo founder, up from 31% in 2024. Switzerland shows no shift yet: about 83% of new firms start with one employee, as in 2013. If AI does push Swiss founders to start alone, [Section 5](#) (p. 14) suggests survival would fall.

PART 2 · DUE DILIGENCE · 6 MIN READ

08 The hidden denominator: why AI success rates mislead

"75% of companies succeed with AI" usually means 75% of the companies that got far enough to be asked.

AT A GLANCE

- Five well-known studies give AI success rates from 5% to 74%.
- The difference comes from who was asked, what counted as success, and over what time.
- For a small firm making one large bet, even a 25–30% failure rate is a survival risk.

SURVEY AUDIT

8.1 How the studies were built

Study	Who was asked	Success means	Window	Result
Google Cloud	3,466 leaders at firms above USD 10m revenue, already using AI	Any ROI	First year	74% achieving ROI
IBM	2,000 CEOs in 33 countries	The ROI they expected	Last few years	25% delivered; 16% scaled
McKinsey	1,993 participants in 105 countries	Any profit (EBIT) effect	Current	88% use; 39% any effect; 6% large
S&P Global	Companies surveyed in 2025	Projects kept vs dropped	One year	42% abandoned most initiatives
MIT NANDA	300+ initiatives, 52 interviews, 153 leaders	Measurable P&L effect	Six months	95% no measurable return

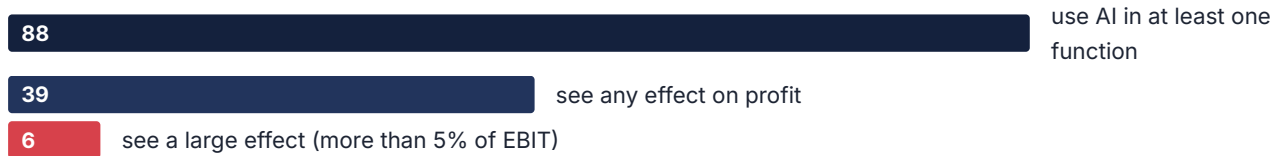
Sources: [CodeIT comparison of Google Cloud and MIT](#); [IBM newsroom](#); [McKinsey State of AI 2025 summary](#); [S&P Global](#) and [MIT NANDA](#) as in Section 7.

8.2 Five reasons the numbers disagree

- 1. Who is in the sample.** Google asked only firms that had already deployed AI; projects that died earlier were never counted. This is survivorship bias.
- 2. What counts as success.** "Any ROI" is far easier to reach than "the ROI we expected" or "a measurable effect on profit".
- 3. The time window.** A project can fail at six months and succeed at eighteen, or the reverse.
- 4. Who answers.** Executives rate projects they sponsored themselves: self-assessments, not measurements.
- 5. Who publishes.** Google and IBM sell AI products; McKinsey sells AI transformation work. That does not make the data wrong, but a careful reader notes it.

8.3 The hidden denominator

Inside one single study, McKinsey, the funnel for every 100 organisations looks like this:



"88% use AI" and "6% get significant value" are both true at once. Which one makes the headline depends on the writer.

KEY FACT · ILLUSTRATION

If about half of AI projects die before production (S&P: 46% of proofs of concept scrapped), a 74% success rate among deployed projects is closer to 40% of all projects started. This combines two samples: read it as a demonstration of the denominator problem, not a statistic.

8.4 Why even a 25–30% failure rate is a serious risk

- **Failure tells you where the AI does not fit.** Klarna let an AI assistant handle two-thirds of customer conversations, the work of about 700 agents. In May 2025 its CEO [admitted the result was lower quality](#) and began hiring humans again. The AI worked for routine questions and failed on complex ones: the failures defined the boundary.
- **Failures are under-reported.** Successes get press releases; failed projects are quietly dropped.
- **Gains are small, losses structural.** Most firms reporting a profit effect say it is under 5% of EBIT; a failed rollout can mean layoffs, lost know-how, lost customers and costly rehiring.
- **Portfolio vs single bet.** A large company can run 40 pilots and accept that a third fail. A small Swiss firm usually gets one bet.

REMEMBER

A 70% success rate is fine for many small, reversible experiments and dangerous for one large, irreversible bet. For small firms, the AI decision itself is a survival risk.

NOTE · THE RESEARCH GAP

A credible study would need every project started (including dropped ones), one definition of success, a fixed time window, an independent publisher, and results by sector and company size. None of the five has all six, and no Swiss sector-level figure exists. A short survey of Swiss SMEs could close this gap.

03

PART 3

The consulting view: from findings to strategy

Why companies in each sector fail, which mistakes repeat, how they could have moved instead, and what is likely to happen next.

IN THIS PART

09	The toolkit: frameworks used	p. 24
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PART 3 · TOOLKIT · 2 MIN READ

09 The toolkit: frameworks used

Standard consulting tools, each chosen to answer one specific question.

Framework	Origin	What it answers here	Where
Hypothesis-driven issue tree	Standard at McKinsey, BCG, Bain	Splits the main question into testable parts	§1 (p. 6)
PESTEL	Classic strategy tool	Which outside forces hit Swiss companies in 2026	§10 (p. 24)
Porter Five Forces	Michael Porter, Harvard	How much competitive pressure each sector faces	§11 (p. 26)
McKinsey 7S	McKinsey	Whether a firm is internally ready for change, such as an AI rollout	§16 (p. 39)
Kotter 8 steps	John Kotter, Harvard	How transformation should be led, and where it breaks	§16 (p. 39)
Three Horizons	McKinsey	Balancing the core business against new bets	§16 (p. 39)
Scenario planning	Developed at Shell	What could happen to 2030 and what to watch	§14 (p. 37)
Pre-mortem, Agile/Scrum	Gary Klein; Scrum Guide	How small firms can test change in reversible steps	§16 (p. 39)

NOTE

In Part 3, facts carry a source. Force ratings, strategy judgements and scenario likelihoods are my own reasoning, marked as such.

PART 3 · ENVIRONMENT · 3 MIN READ

10 Switzerland in 2026: the environment

A recovery on fragile ground: tariffs, energy and the franc can turn quickly.

PESTEL factor	What is happening	Who it hits
Political: US tariffs	39% on Swiss goods from August 2025, cut to a 15% ceiling by the November 2025 deal; flat 10% since February 2026 after a US court ruling; up to 15% on pharma since April 2026 (economiesuisse)	Pharma, watches, machinery and their Swiss suppliers
Economic: growth	SECO raised its 2026 GDP forecast from 0.9% to 1.7%, helped by pharma and a weaker franc (SECO)	Positive for exporters
Economic: rates	SNB rate at 0%; KOF expects one 0.25-point rise in December 2026, inflation about 0.6% (KOF via finews)	Leveraged firms, construction, real estate
Economic: energy, conflict	Middle East conflict and high energy prices named as key risks by SECO	Hospitality, transport, manufacturing

PESTEL factor	What is happening	Who it hits
Social: habits	Less alcohol, shorter lunches, online shopping, shopping across the border	Restaurants, shops
Technological: AI	A third of Swiss VC; SME use 22% → 34% in a year	Knowledge work (§7 (p. 18))
Legal: bankruptcy law	Since 2025 tax and social-insurance claims go through bankruptcy proceedings	Weak firms with public debts; inflates statistics
Legal: health tariffs	TARDOC replaced the 20-year-old TARMED tariff on 1 January 2026	Doctors and outpatient practices

REMEMBER

For most Swiss small firms, the biggest threats in 2026 are costs, demand and competition, not AI.

PART 3 · FIVE FORCES · 3 MIN READ

11 Competitive pressure by sector

The sectors with the lowest survival face the highest combined pressure.

Sector	5-yr survival	New entrants	Rivalry	Substitutes	Buyer power	Supplier power	Overall
Hospitality	38%	High	High	Medium	Medium	High (rents, staff)	Very high
Trade and retail	44%	High	High	High (online, Temu)	High	Medium	Very high
Transport	45%	Medium	High	Medium	High	High (fuel)	High
ICT and IT services	46%	High	High	High (AI, offshore)	High	Low	High
Finance and insurance	47%	Low to high	High	Medium	High	Medium	High
Professional services	50%	High	High	Rising (AI)	High	Low	High
Construction	51%	Medium	High	Low	Medium	High (materials)	Medium-high
Health and social	63%	Low (licences)	Medium	Low	Low (insured)	Medium	Low

Survival: BFS, 2018 cohort. Force ratings: my own assessment from the facts in this report.

KEY FACT

Health is the only sector where entry is restricted by qualifications and licences, and it has by far the highest survival. Barriers to entry protect those who get in.

→ **Check this point** against the sector chart: **Section 3** (p. 10)

PART 3 · SECTOR DEEP DIVES · 16 MIN READ

12 Eight sector deep dives

For each sector: the facts, where companies go wrong, how they could move, and what is likely next.

Sector	Survival	Main failure driver	AI role	Go to
Hospitality	38%	Cost squeeze: rents, wages, energy	Minor	12.1 (p. 28)
Retail and trade	44%	Platforms and cross-border shopping	Indirect	12.2 (p. 29)
Construction and trades	51%	Cash flow and pricing	Minor	12.3 (p. 30)
IT services and software	46%	Hourly billing under AI pressure	Direct threat	12.4 (p. 31)
Finance, fintech, crypto	47%	Funding and price cycles	Mixed	12.5 (p. 32)
Health and life sciences	63%	Regulation and geopolitics	Minor	12.6 (p. 33)
Consulting and marketing	≈50%	Crowding, no niche	Boom and bust	12.7 (p. 34)
Translation, media, office	n/a	Customers replace them with AI	Direct replacement	12.8 (p. 35)

REMEMBER

Across all eight sectors, the same three mistakes repeat: an irreversible bet before the concept is proven, no clear position, and one person carrying everything.

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · 38% SURVIVE

12.1 Hospitality

Hospitality fails through a cost squeeze, not lack of guests.

THE FACTS

- Restaurant revenue fell 4.8% and hotel revenue 0.9% in Q1 2026 against a year earlier ([GastroSuisse/KOF](#)).
- Owners name staff shortages, rising rents, changing habits, falling sales and high staff costs; GastroSuisse says margins have eroded for years ([Blick](#)).
- Chains share staff across sites and control costs better than single restaurants. Mountain hotels did well while city restaurants struggled.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

- 1. The irreversible bet first:** long lease and full fit-out before the concept is proven.
- 2. Stuck in the middle:** neither cheapest nor clearly special, Porter's weakest position.
- 3. One person carries everything:** chef, manager and accountant.
- 4. No numbers:** no tracking of cost per cover or staff cost share.

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **Test before signing:** pop-ups, shared kitchens, short leases.
- **Pick a clear position:** a focused niche instead of serving everyone.
- **Share fixed costs** with peers: staff pools, joint purchasing.
- **Simple digital tools:** booking, scheduling, stock control.

SCENARIO · LIKELIHOOD HIGH (MY JUDGEMENT)

If energy prices stay high and the franc strengthens again, expect consolidation: chains and well-capitalised groups gain, independent full-service restaurants shrink.

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · 44% SURVIVE

12.2 Retail and trade

Squeezed from two sides: foreign platforms online and shops across the border offline.

THE FACTS

- Swiss retail grew only 1.0% in 2025: food +2.1%, non-food -2.7% ([NielsenIQ via Handel Heute](#)).
- Online sales reached CHF 15.8bn, 12.5% of retail and 19.7% of non-food; 41% of retailers feel Temu and Shein strongly or moderately ([Swiss Post](#)).
- Temu alone: about CHF 1bn Swiss sales in 2025, about 50,000 orders a day ([Netzwoche](#)). Discounters Action and Rossmann entered in 2025.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

1. **Fighting on price** against platforms with global scale.
2. **Half-done digital transformation:** a website without stock data, delivery or service behind it.
3. **Generalist range:** nothing is a reason to visit.

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **Compete on what platforms cannot copy:** advice, fitting, repair, rental, local speed, trusted Swiss standards.
- **Use marketplaces as a channel:** Swiss retailers can sell on Temu itself since September 2025.
- **Narrow the range** to a niche and own it.

SCENARIO · LIKELIHOOD MEDIUM (MY JUDGEMENT)

If Switzerland tightens rules on foreign platforms, as the Council of States has demanded, non-food shops get modest relief before 2028. If not, independent non-food retail keeps shrinking.

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · 51% SURVIVE

12.3 Construction and specialised trades

Small firms fail on cash flow and pricing, not on lack of work.

THE FACTS

- Construction is among the sectors most affected by bankruptcies in 2026, with trade and hospitality ([Creditreform via cash.ch](#)).
- New specialised construction firms rose 5.8% in 2023 (BFS): demand for trades remains solid. SECO expected construction investment to grow about 1.6% in 2026.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

1. **Underpriced fixed-price bids** that carry material and labour cost increases.
2. **Cash-flow blindness:** late payments in, wages and suppliers out.
3. **One general contractor** provides most revenue.
4. **No succession plan.**

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **Protect margins in the contract:** price-adjustment clauses, deposits, stage payments.
- **Specialise** in lasting demand, such as renovation and energy-efficiency upgrades.
- **Spread customer risk.**
- **Simple digital tools** for estimating and invoicing.

SCENARIO

A single 0.25-point SNB rate rise in December 2026, as KOF expects, would have only a small effect. Cost discipline matters far more than interest rates for small trades firms.

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · 46% SURVIVE

12.4 IT services and software

If AI does part of the coding, selling hours becomes selling less.

THE FACTS

- New IT services firms fell 7.1% in 2023 (BFS), while ICT venture capital rose almost 150% in 2025 to CHF 774m (SVCR): money returned, to fewer, larger companies.
- ICT has the highest AI use of any sector, and is the only one where AI is often the business model (UBS).
- Only 34% of SMEs have AI data rules; only 2% of micro-firms use AI systematically.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

1. **Billing by the hour** while AI speeds up the work: productivity gains go to the client.
2. **Generic positioning:** "we build websites and apps" competes with freelancers, offshore teams and AI tools.
3. **One large client.**

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **From hours to outcomes:** packaged, fixed-price services (AI integration, security audit, data-protection setup).
- **Turn the gap into the offer:** most SMEs use AI without rules; help them set it up safely, with Swiss hosting (rated 8.7/10 in importance).
- **Specialise in regulated fields:** finance, health, public sector.

SCENARIO · LIKELIHOOD HIGH (MY JUDGEMENT)

If AI coding tools keep improving at the current pace, revenue per developer hour falls for generic IT firms. Firms that package outcomes win.

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · 47% SURVIVE

12.5 Finance, fintech and crypto

Licensed firms are protected; consumer fintech and crypto ride funding and price cycles.

THE FACTS

- Swiss fintech rounds fell from 41 in 2024 to 30 in 2025, far below 2021–22 levels (SVCR).
- Crypto Valley had 1,766 active blockchain firms at the end of 2025, but growth slowed to 1% a year; Zug lost four and has 715 ([Crypto Valley Journal](#)).
- Top-50 valuation fell 21.3% to USD 467bn while funding rose 37% to USD 728m ([CV VC](#)). The ecosystem is shifting from tokens to infrastructure.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

1. **Business models tied to token prices.**
2. **Underestimating regulation:** licences, compliance, bank access.
3. **Consumer fintech against entrenched players** (banks, Twint) without a clear edge.

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **Sell infrastructure** (compliance, custody, data) rather than chase consumers.
- **Partner with banks** instead of replacing them.
- **Treat regulation as a moat**, as health does.

NOTE · THE ZUG LINK

Crypto explains only part of the Zug puzzle: Zug has about 715 blockchain firms in total, against roughly 1,800 new companies every year. [Section 2](#) (p. 8)

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · 63% SURVIVE

12.6 Health and life sciences

The strongest sector. Its risks come from regulation and geopolitics, not competition.

THE FACTS

- New health companies rose 16.7% in 2023, the strongest growth of any large sector (BFS).
- Biotech received a record CHF 946m of VC in 2025; Basel-Stadt took 57.7% (SVCR).
- Pharma is nearly half of Swiss goods exports to the US and faces US tariffs of up to 15% since April 2026, with exceptions.
- TARDOC replaced TARMED on 1 January 2026; doctors fear lump sums will not cover complex cases, and rural practices often find no successor ([Zuger Zeitung](#)).

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

1. **The single-doctor practice** carrying admin, billing change and succession alone.
2. **Single-asset biotech:** one drug, one trial.
3. **Late-stage funding dependence:** 88% of Swiss deep-tech rounds above USD 100m come from foreign investors ([Deep Tech Report](#)).

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **Group practices and shared services** for billing, IT and staff; easier succession.
- **Telemedicine**, which TARDOC values better than TARMED did.
- **Partnering and licensing** with large pharma.

SCENARIO · LIKELIHOOD MEDIUM TO HIGH (MY JUDGEMENT)

If US drug-pricing pressure or tariffs rise further, Basel feels it first: big pharma cuts costs, then suppliers, labs and service firms around it.

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · ABOUT 50% SURVIVE

12.7 Consulting, marketing and professional services

The sector most likely to see an AI-driven boom and bust.

THE FACTS

- Consulting was among the two largest founding categories in 2025, with 5,733 new register entries (IFJ).
- In 2023, new consulting firms rose 3.7% and advertising and market research firms 15.8% (BFS).
- These sectors already had the highest closure rates: 9.5 and 9.0 per 100 active firms in 2021, against 5.1 in health.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

1. **No niche:** competing with everyone, including AI tools.
2. **Selling outputs AI can produce:** reports, slides, posts, market overviews.
3. **No recurring revenue.**
4. **The network runs dry** after one or two years.

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **Sell implementation:** AI can write the deck; it cannot run the change inside a client.
- **A niche with proof:** one industry or problem, with published cases.
- **Recurring revenue:** retainers, managed services, training.
- **Price outcomes, not hours.**

SCENARIO · LIKELIHOOD HIGH (MY JUDGEMENT)

Cheap AI tools keep foundings high in consulting and marketing, and many of these firms close within two to three years. Watch the next BFS releases.

SECTOR DEEP DIVE · AI-REPLACED WORK

12.8 Translation, media and office services

Here the customer becomes the competitor.

THE FACTS

- In 2023, new publishing firms fell 14.6%, office-support firms 15.6%, design and translation firms 2.6% (BFS).
- Translation (52%) and correspondence (47%) are the two most common uses of AI among Swiss SMEs (AXA/Sotomo): work these firms used to sell.
- Clerical work has the highest generative-AI exposure of any occupation group (ILO 2025). Even DeepL cut a quarter of its staff in 2026.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

1. **Pricing per word or page** while AI makes words almost free.
2. **Waiting for demand to return.** It will not, for standard texts.

HOW THEY COULD MOVE

- **Sell what carries liability:** certified, legal, medical and financial translation.
- **From producing to checking:** quality assurance of AI output, priced by risk.
- **Premium human service**, the Klarna lesson.
§8 (p. 21)

REMEMBER

When customers can do the work themselves with AI, the only defensible offer is responsibility, judgement and trust.

PART 3 · REGIONS · 3 MIN READ

13 Regions: the strategic reading

Each canton made a different trade-off between volume and durability.

Canton	Strategic profile	Strength	Risk	What it should do
Zurich	Diversified hub; 40% of Swiss VC; best survival (52.3%)	Talent, capital, many sectors	High costs; AI pressure on a large service economy	Keep the mix diverse; support firms that scale, not only those that start
Zug	Formation machine; highest founding and closure rates	Low taxes, global firms, Crypto Valley	Mobile, foreign-owned, cycle-driven firms leave as easily as they arrive	Measure success by survival and jobs, not registrations
Lucerne	Quiet improver: 48.7% → 52.0%, almost no VC, lowest closure rate	Stable local SMEs	Low growth and innovation; few scale-ups	Add a growth layer (university spin-offs, regional investors) without losing stability
Basel-Stadt	Life-science cluster; 57.7% of Swiss biotech VC	World-class pharma and biotech	Concentration exposed to US tariffs and drug pricing	Broaden suppliers and services beyond big pharma
Bern	Lowest founding rate (3.8 per 1,000); near-average survival	Stable, public-sector-anchored	Little dynamism	Lower barriers: faster permits, founder support

Strength, risk and recommendations: my own assessment from the facts in this report.

REMEMBER

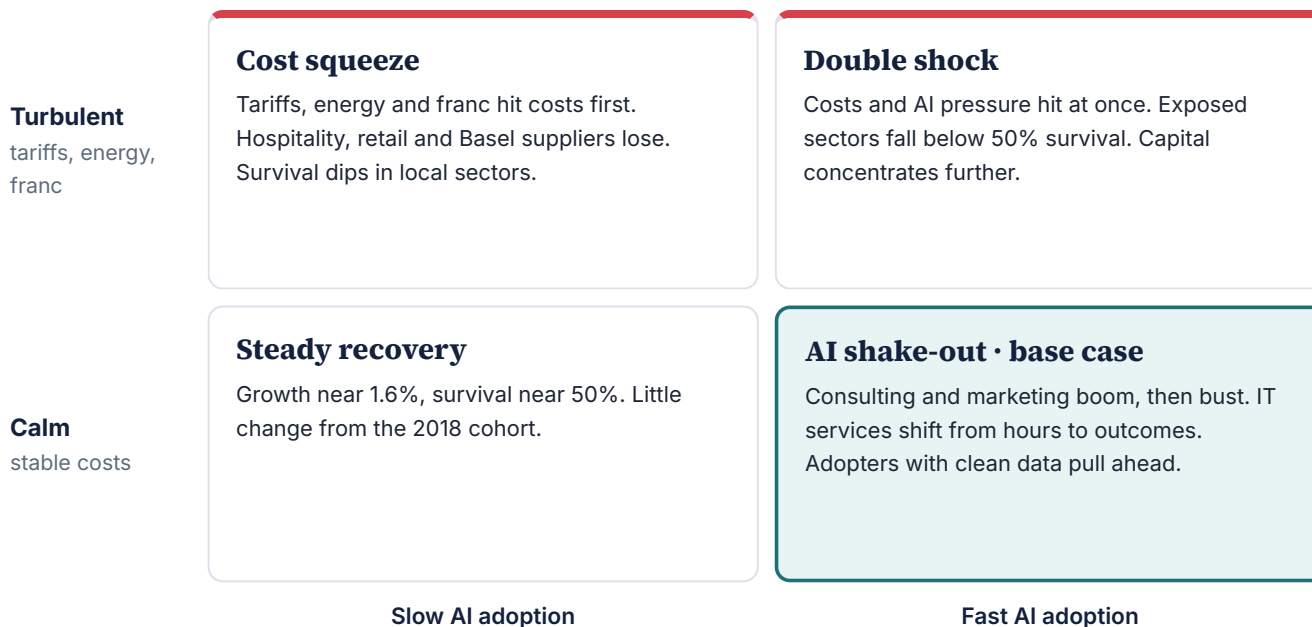
Zug maximises volume; Lucerne maximises durability; Zurich manages both.

PART 3 · SCENARIOS · 3 MIN READ

14 Four scenarios to 2030

The base case is an AI shake-out, with costs as the wild card.

Two forces will shape survival most: how fast AI spreads, and how turbulent the outside world gets (tariffs, energy, the franc). Crossing them gives four futures.



Scenario map: own analysis. Likelihoods are my judgement.

Why the AI shake-out is my base case: AI adoption keeps accelerating (SME use rose from 22% to 34% in one year) while the economy grows moderately (SECO: 1.7% in 2026, 1.6% in 2027). The wild card is cost turbulence: if tariffs, energy or the franc turn against Switzerland at the same time, the double shock follows.

NOTE

Scenarios are not forecasts. They show what to prepare for, and which signposts to watch (next section).

PART 3 · TRIGGER CHAINS · 4 MIN READ

15 If this happens, then what

Each trigger sets off a chain. The signposts tell you which way it is going.

Trigger	First effect	Knock-on effect	Who loses / wins	Likelihood	Signpost
SNB +0.25 pts, Dec 2026	Slightly dearer borrowing	Marginal pressure on construction, real estate	Small overall	High	SNB decision
US raises pharma tariffs or presses drug prices	Big pharma cuts costs	Fewer orders for Basel suppliers and labs	Basel loses most	Med-high	US rulings; pharma results
Franc strengthens as a safe haven	More shopping and holidays abroad	Fewer guests and shoppers at home	Hospitality, retail, exporters lose	Medium	EUR/CHF; SNB
Energy stays high (Middle East)	Higher operating costs	Thinner margins, more closures	Hospitality, transport lose	Medium	Energy prices
AI agents mature quickly	Less paid office, translation, basic IT work	One-person consulting boom, then closures	AI-native firms win	High	BFS foundings by industry
AI valuations correct	Fewer, smaller AI rounds	Capital flows back to non-AI startups	Fintech, cleantech, hardware win	Medium	AI share of VC
Swiss rules on foreign platforms	Higher costs for Temu, Shein	Some sales return to Swiss shops	Non-food retail wins a little	Medium	Parliament
TARDOC underpays complex care	Solo practices lose money on complex cases	Consolidation into group practices	Groups win, solo practices lose	Med-high	FMH evaluations
Bankruptcy-law effect fades, 2027	Bankruptcy numbers fall	Headlines call it a recovery; part is statistical	Readers who check the method	High	D&B, Creditreform

Likelihood ratings: my own judgement based on the facts in this report.

REMEMBER

The chains connect. A stronger franc, high energy prices and AI pressure can hit the same small firm at once. That compounding turns a difficult year into a closure.

PART 3 · RECOMMENDATIONS · 4 MIN READ

16 Recommendations and an agile playbook

Survive the first five years by keeping early bets small and reversible, and build barriers competitors and AI cannot easily cross.

Who	What to do
Founders	Do not start alone: start with a partner or a first hire. Choose a niche with a barrier (skills, licence, trust). Test demand before signing long leases or large contracts.
SME owners	Put AI on back-office tasks first, with data rules in place. Track cash runway and unit costs monthly. Share fixed costs with peers.
Investors	Look past AI labels: ask what part of the value survives when AI tools get cheaper. Non-AI startups trade at lower valuations, which can be an opportunity.
Cantons	Measure economic health by survival and jobs, not registrations. Publish canton-by-sector survival data. Support years two and three, not only the founding.
Consultants	Sell implementation and measurable outcomes. Run pre-mortems on every large client bet, especially AI rollouts.

An agile playbook for small firms

- 1. Pre-mortem:** before a big commitment, imagine it failed a year from now and list why. Fix the top three reasons first.
- 2. Smallest test first:** a pop-up instead of a lease, a pilot instead of a rollout, one client instead of a launch.
- 3. Short cycles:** review every two to four weeks, like a Scrum sprint, and decide to continue, change or stop.
- 4. Kill criteria in advance:** decide before starting what result means stop.
- 5. Readiness check (McKinsey 7S):** strategy, structure, systems, shared values, style, staff and skills must all support the change, not just the technology.
- 6. Lead change step by step (Kotter):** urgency, a small owning team, and visible quick wins. Most transformations fail when no early win is visible.
- 7. Balance the portfolio (Three Horizons):** most effort on the core, some on extending it, a small share on new bets.

SIDE NOTE

Agile and Scrum come from software, but their core idea fits any small firm: make change in small steps you can reverse, and inspect results often.

REMEMBER

Agile methods turn one big, irreversible bet into many small, reversible experiments. That is exactly what a 70% success rate requires. [Section 8](#) (p. 21)

04

PART 4

Limits and conclusion

What the data can and cannot say, which headlines to distrust, and the final answer.

IN THIS PART

17	What the data cannot tell us	p. 41
18	Data due diligence: five headlines that mislead	p. 41
19	Conclusion	p. 43
20	Sources	p. 44

PART 4 · LIMITS · 2 MIN READ

17 What the data cannot tell us

Five limits that shape how far these findings go.

- 1. Patterns, not causes.** The data shows that small starts survive less, not that hiring would make a company survive. Every "why" in this report is a hypothesis until tested.
- 2. A two-year lag.** BFS survival data ends in 2023. The 2022–23 rate rise, the 2025 bankruptcy-law change and the AI wave are not fully visible yet.
- 3. No canton-by-sector view.** BFS publishes survival by canton or by sector, not both. I cannot say whether Zug's ICT firms do worse than Zurich's.
- 4. Closure is not always failure.** A company can close because it was sold, merged or its owner retired.
- 5. Different sector definitions** in BFS and the VC report; VC figures for Bern and Lucerne are minimums.

PART 4 · DUE DILIGENCE · 4 MIN READ

18 Data due diligence: five headlines that mislead

Before using any number, ask: who was counted, what counted as success, over what time, and who published it?

Claim	Source	Reliability	Weak point
Survival by canton, sector, size	BFS company demography	High	Two-year lag; holdings excluded
Founding and closure trends by industry	BFS STAT-TAB	High	Only 2023 is after ChatGPT
VC by canton and sector	Swiss Venture Capital Report 2026	High	Disclosed rounds only
AI share of Swiss VC	EY Startup Barometer 2026	Med-high	EY defines "AI startup"
AI adoption in firms	AXA/Sotomo, UBS, KOF, HWZ, BFS	Medium	Each defines "using AI" differently
AI project returns	MIT, IBM, McKinsey, S&P, Google	Medium	Selective samples, self-reporting
AI exposure of jobs	ILO 2025	High	Exposure is a ceiling, not job loss
Solo-founder trend	Carta	Low for CH	US, venture-backed only

Five gaps between headlines and reality

- 1. "Record company foundings" include paper companies.** Register counts include holdings, among the largest groups of new entries. BFS, counting only operating firms, showed foundings flat in 2023.

2. **"Record bankruptcies" are partly a legal effect.** Since 2025, tax and social-insurance claims go through bankruptcy proceedings; [Dun & Bradstreet](#) says comparisons with earlier years are no longer valid.
3. **"60% of firms use AI" does not mean AI works there.** Adoption ranges from about 8% of small firms (KOF) to about 60% of all firms (UBS), with 2% of micro-firms using it systematically.
4. **AI success rates contradict each other, from 5% to 74%.** [Section 8](#) (p. 21)
5. **Even the totals disagree.** EY puts Swiss VC at more than CHF 3.3bn in 2025; the SVCR at CHF 2.95bn.

19 Conclusion

Why half of new Swiss companies close within five years, and what the other half do differently.

New Swiss companies mostly fail because of how they start and which market they enter, not because of where they are or how much money they raise.

1. Start

Solo 49% vs teams of 10+ 68%. Capital and a team at the start are the strongest protection.

2. Market

Easy-entry, crowded sectors survive worst; sectors protected by qualifications survive best.

3. Place

Location matters less, mostly through the type of company a place attracts.

4. Money

VC reaches a few hundred of 46,000+ new firms a year; it does not explain survival.

5. AI

Not yet the main cause, but crowding knowledge work and concentrating capital.

→ So what

Start with a team, pick a market with a barrier, keep early bets small and reversible.

REMEMBER

The survivors start with a team, enter a market with a real barrier or stable demand, and keep their early bets small and reversible.

What I will research next

- **Zug:** how much of its churn comes from foreign-owned and mobile companies.
- **Lucerne:** how its companies survive without venture capital.
- **AI in Swiss SMEs:** a short survey of what firms tried, what they dropped, and why, to close the research gap in [Section 8](#) (p. 21).
- **2027 update:** rerun the analysis when BFS publishes the next cohorts.

PART 4 · REFERENCE

20 Sources

Every number in this report traces back to one of these. Accessed September–October 2026.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Thank you for reading

This report is the first in a series of independent, consulting-style studies on the Swiss economy: one sharp question, official data, built-from-scratch Power BI analysis, and a clear "so what".



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What I did in this project

- **Framing:** question, MECE issue tree and testable hypotheses.
- **Data:** collected raw BFS and venture-capital data; cleaned and translated it in Python; validated totals against published figures.
- **Analysis and visuals:** built the data model and all four data charts in Power BI.
- **Research:** checked every explanation against at least two sources, and audited the sources themselves.
- **Strategy:** PESTEL, five forces, eight sector diagnoses, scenarios and an agile playbook.

LET'S TALK

If you work on Swiss startups, SMEs, venture capital or AI adoption and see something I missed, I would like to hear it. Connect with me on LinkedIn: [linkedin.com/in/salmanshaik27](https://www.linkedin.com/in/salmanshaik27).